Alexis Diamond, Ph.D.

CONTACT

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Google Scholar (16,000+ citations)
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PROFILE

Evaluation scientist, applying two decades of evaluation expertise to **AI model safety**. My work has been judging whether an evaluation measures what it claims to, setting standards for evaluation, and training evaluators. As **IFC's global lead for evaluation** I set the methodological standard for the institution, quality-assured evaluations in 30+ countries and trained hundreds of staff. As methods expert for the **Independent Office of Evaluation at IFAD**, the United Nations' International Fund for Agricultural Development, I worked on an evaluation of IFAD's entire impact-assessment system, replicating code and data. I trained under Donald Rubin and, with Abadie and Hainmueller, co-authored the foundational papers on the **synthetic control method** (*JASA* 2010; *AJPS* 2015) and its *Synth* software (200,000+ cumulative CRAN downloads). My first research was on **catastrophic risk**: at RAND I built early-warning systems for bioterror detection and ran covert tests of bioterror preparedness. My most recent paper, *Who Took the Hint?*, shows that the standard score for **chain-of-thought monitorability**, a proposed safety control for frontier models, grades monitors against a different quantity from the one they are meant to detect, and proposes remedies. I co-founded the benchmark portal rctvsobs.org and advise nine student AI safety capstone projects. Over ten years I have scoped and supervised 60+ theses to completion, and I have served as a grant-proposal reviewer for the **National Science Foundation**.

AI SAFETY

Who Took the Hint? **Applying Methods of Causal Inference to Evaluate Chain of Thought Monitorability** *2026*

Sole author — submitted to the Agent Evaluation Science symposium, New York (November 2026); paper and supplement at github.com/alexisjdiamond/who-took-the-hint

- Addresses a measurement problem in **AI control**, how to tell whether a model's reasoning can be monitored: shows that the intervention-based monitorability evaluations reported in OpenAI system cards are **encouragement designs with one-sided noncompliance**, and that the score (g-mean^2) grades monitors against what the experiment identifies rather than the cue use they are asked to detect, a gap that grows with the base rate
- Works three cases in which a correctly computed score supports the wrong conclusion, including a monitor that misses half of cue use and still scores as perfect
- Proposes remedies: report the intention-to-treat effect alongside the score, bounds and a sensitivity analysis for monitor recall, a cross-variant consistency check, placebo cues, and six **reporting conditions** for monitorability results

Minerva University — AI Safety Capstone *2026–2027*

Secondary Advisor — nine student projects on reward hacking, evaluation integrity, deception detection, monitoring and unlearning

AIxBio Africa *2026*

Facilitator — Introduction to AI & Biosecurity: An African Perspective (Cohort 1); leading six live discussion sessions for a participant group

Training: **BlueDot Impact** — Technical AI Safety (completed Sept. 2026); Technical AI Safety Project Sprint (in progress). **GEAR** — Gradual Empowerment Alignment Research, ARENA-based course (in progress, Oct.–Dec. 2026). **Lens Academy** — Compute Verification 1: technical and governance challenges of verifying international AI agreements (in progress).

Evaluation Leadership

Two decades judging, designing, and setting standards for evaluations, chiefly at international funders (IFC, IFAD, ADB).

International Finance Corporation (IFC), World Bank Group *2006–2024*
Impact & Performance Evaluation Global Lead, Washington D.C. (2011–2015); Regional M&E Officer, Hanoi (2009–2011); M&E Officer (2006–2009); Consultant (2017–2024)

- Led IFC's global impact- and performance-evaluation strategy and served as technical lead on all evaluations and research studies, **setting the methodological standard** across the institution
- Managed evaluation officers across six country offices; **hired and managed external evaluation consultants** for IFC's global private-sector development portfolio; **trained hundreds of staff** worldwide on measurement and evaluation
- **Portfolio oversight:** designed IFC's evaluation IT system for real-time supervision of the global evaluation portfolio; aggregated results and lessons for portfolio reviews and donor reporting; conducted in-country project reviews in Latin America, Asia, Africa, and Central/Eastern Europe
- As consultant, **quality-assured and led impact evaluations across 30+ countries** and advised on applications of the synthetic control method; worked with the Compliance Advisor Ombudsman on environmental and social standards

International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD) *2023–2025*
Senior Evaluation Consultant, Independent Office of Evaluation — methods expert on a corporate-level **evaluation of IFAD's Impact Assessment System**, the basis of its donor reporting

- Tested the project sampling frame for representativeness across three replenishment cycles
- Systematically reviewed a 25% sample of impact assessments, with **full replication of code and data** in eight deep-dive cases
- Assessed the aggregation of results for corporate reporting against meta-analysis principles; synthesized findings into a rated evaluation report with recommendations

Asian Development Bank, Manila *2018–2019*
Evaluation Consultant — developed and piloted an ex-post assessment protocol with the Independent Evaluation Group; **assessed project completion reports against a complex rubric**; designed M&E training for advisory staff

Caucasus Research Resource Center (CRRC), Tbilisi, Georgia *2016–2018*
Impact Evaluation Consultant & Principal Investigator — co-led a quasi-experimental evaluation of a major IFAD-funded agriculture, infrastructure, and finance program; senior economist for UN Women–sponsored studies of female economic activity in Georgia and Armenia

Dalberg Global Development Advisors *2017*
Impact Evaluation Design Consultant — advised on quasi-experimental design for a Google/USAID broadband program; delivered statistical-methods training to staff

Audible.com (Amazon subsidiary) *2017–2018*
Impact Evaluation Design Consultant — designed a randomized controlled trial to estimate the effect of audiobooks on children's literacy, and ran a transparent, competitive process to select the consultants who implemented it

German Federal Employment Agency / Datametrics *2004–2006*
Evaluation Consultant — built statistical software (*TrEffer*) with Donald Rubin's team to evaluate Germany's multibillion-euro job-training programs: matching estimators at national scale, in production

Web Marketing, LLC, New York *1999–2000*
Account Executive (campaign impact measurement) — evaluated the impact of clients' direct-marketing advertising campaigns; managed client relationships and negotiated partnership terms

Catastrophic Risk & Adversarial Testing

RAND Corporation, Arlington, Virginia *2004–2005*
Summer Associate, then Consultant — work for the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services on detection of and response to low-probability, high-consequence events

- Developed a statistical **early-warning system for bioterror response** in the Washington, D.C. area — detecting a rare adversarial event against a noisy baseline, where both false negatives and false alarms are costly
- **Served as the covert caller and data collector** on a structured test of emergency response: placed simulated urgent case-report calls to health departments in nineteen metropolitan areas, sustaining a credible clinician persona with expert subjects, and collected the response-time data against the CDC 24/7 standard (*Health Affairs*)
- Evaluated competing **statistical methods for syndromic surveillance** — i.e. which detection methods actually work on real data, and under what assumptions they fail
- Built preparedness training and assessment exercises adopted by local public health agencies
- As consultant, worked with HHS to develop **public health emergency preparedness objectives** and continuous quality improvement models

Academic Appointments

Minerva University, San Francisco *2015–present*
Professor, Computational Sciences; AI Fellow (2025–2026, first to hold the role)

- Supervised **60+ student theses** over 10 years in data science, causal inference, machine learning, and impact evaluation — scoping tractable empirical questions and driving them to a written result on a fixed timeline
- Wrote and shepherded Minerva's institution-wide **AI Use Policy**, adopted across all faculty
- Designed and taught undergraduate and graduate courses in statistics, computer science, logic, and microeconomics

Central European University, School of Public Policy — Visiting Chair, Vienna (2025); Visiting Professor, Budapest (2015–2017)
Taught machine learning, results measurement, and program evaluation to MA and PhD students; advised on quantitative methods.

Harvard University, John F. Kennedy School of Government — Visiting Professor (2013)
Taught Impact Evaluation (ECON128), satisfying the PhD econometrics requirement.

Proposal & Peer Review

Grant proposal review: **National Science Foundation**.
Journals: Review of Economics & Statistics, *American Journal of Political Science*, *Journal of Development Economics*, *World Development*, *Review of Financial Studies*, *Journal of Population Economics*, *Journal of Peace Research*, *Journal of International Public Management*.

Methods, Software & Benchmarks

***Synth* — R package for synthetic control methods** *2011–present*
Co-author (with Abadie & Hainmueller) — **200,000+ cumulative CRAN downloads**; the reference implementation of the synthetic control estimator, used across economics, political science, epidemiology, and public health (*Journal of Statistical Software*, 2011).

rctvsobs.org — causal-inference benchmark portal *2026*
Co-founder & co-builder — open portal curating **paired RCT/observational benchmarks** (LaLonde and others), so that estimators can be scored against known experimental ground truth.

LLM systems *2024–present*
Designed and shipped three applications on the Anthropic Claude API, each evaluated against rubrics and real classroom use: **SupaNerd**, an adaptive assessment platform in production use; **Coursebuilder Agent**, a human-in-the-loop agent that proposes lesson-plan revisions as reviewable diffs for a human to approve; and **GWiz**, a grading assistant built to make model judgments auditable against an explicit rubric. Also directed a student team that built **Class Transcriber**, a local, privacy-preserving transcription pipeline (2025).

Methods: experimental design (RCTs), psychometrics and construct validity, causal inference under confounding (synthetic control, genetic matching, propensity methods), meta-analysis, benchmark construction and validation. *Code:* R (advanced), Python (intermediate).

Publications

16,000+ citations (Google Scholar).

AI safety

- Who Took the Hint? Applying Methods of Causal Inference to Evaluate Chain of Thought Monitorability, submitted to the Agent Evaluation Science symposium (2026).

Peer-reviewed papers & book chapters

- Synthetic Control Methods for Comparative Case Studies: Estimating the Effect of California's Tobacco Control Program (with Abadie & Hainmueller), *Journal of the American Statistical Association* (2010). *Gosnell Prize; among the journal's ten most-cited articles, 2009–2011.*
- Genetic Matching for Estimating Causal Effects: A General Multivariate Matching Method for Achieving Balance in Observational Studies (with Sekhon), *Review of Economics and Statistics* (2013). *Gosnell Prize.*
- Comparative Politics and the Synthetic Control Method (with Abadie & Hainmueller), *American Journal of Political Science* (2015).
- *Synth*: An R Package for Synthetic Control Methods in Comparative Case Studies (with Abadie & Hainmueller), *Journal of Statistical Software* (2011).
- Estimating Poverty Rates in Subnational Populations of Interest: An Assessment of the Simple Poverty Scorecard (with Skoufias et al.), *World Development* (2020).
- Public Health Response to Urgent Case Reports: A Structured Test Reveals Gaps in Response Times in Nineteen Communities Across the Country (with Dausey & Lurie), *Health Affairs* (2005).
- Implementing a Community-based Oral Health Care Program: Lessons Learned (with R. Diamond, Litwak & Marshall), *Journal of Public Health Dentistry* (2003).
- Evaluating Statistical Methods for Syndromic Surveillance (with Stoto et al.), in Wilson, Wilson & Olwell (eds.), *Statistical Methods in Counterterrorism*, Springer (2006).

Institutional technical reports

- Bioterrorism Preparedness Training and Assessment Exercises for Local Public Health Agencies, RAND Corporation, TR-261-DHHS (2005).
- Tests to Evaluate Public Health Disease Reporting Systems in Local Public Health Agencies, RAND Corporation, TR-260-DHHS (2005).
- Women's Economic Activity and Engagement in the Informal Sector in Georgia, UN Women and the Swiss Agency for Development and Cooperation (2018).
- Women's Economic Activity and Engagement in the Informal Sector in Armenia, UN Women and the Swiss Agency for Development and Cooperation (2018).

Working & discussion papers

- Synthetic Control Methods for Comparative Case Studies: Estimating the Effect of California's Tobacco Control Program, NBER Working Paper / Harvard University (2007, 2009).
- Genetic Matching for Estimating Causal Effects, Harvard Kennedy School Faculty Research Working Paper / UC Berkeley (2005–2011).
- Estimating Poverty Rates in Target Populations: An Assessment of the Simple Poverty Scorecard and Alternative Approaches, World Bank Policy Research Working Paper No. 7709 (2016).
- Poverty Literature Review: Microfinance and Poverty Reduction, World Bank Group Working Paper (2012).

Education

Harvard University — Ph.D., Political Economy & Government, 2008
Supervisor: Donald B. Rubin (John L. Loeb Professor of Statistics). *Dissertation:* Reliable Causal Inference in Non-experimental Settings

Carleton University — M.A., International Affairs, 1999 (Canada–US Fulbright Fellow)
Alfred University — B.A., Economics (Honors) & Mathematics, 1997 (Phi Beta Kappa)

Honors

Two-time **Gosnell Prize** winner (APSA, 2005 & 2007); World Bank "Knowbel" Prize (2013 & 2023); **IFC Corporate Award** for an agribusiness evaluation in India that took a pilot project to scale (2011); IFC Award for support to IFC's community-investment financial valuation tool (2009).

Selected Talks

- *Presenter*, "Augmentation, Not Automation: AI-Enabled Rigor and Access Across Disciplines," WSCUC ARC2026, San Francisco (2026)
- *Featured Speaker*, "AI, Jobs, and Education," Root Impact, Seoul (2025)
- *Public Talk*, "Age of AI," National Taiwan University Design & Innovation School (2025)
- *Featured Speaker*, "Lean Impact Evaluation," Mingyi Foundation, Taiwan (2025)
- *Featured Speaker*, Amazon.com Friday Economics Seminar, Seattle (2019)
- *Presenter*, World Bank Results Forum, Washington D.C. (2019)
- *Keynote*, Methodological Conference on Research for Development, Tbilisi (2017)
- *Presenter*, American Evaluation Association Annual Conference, Denver (2014)
- *Invited Talk*, Department for International Development (DFID), London (2012)
- *Invited Talk*, Advanced Statistics Workshop, Harvard University (2004, 2006)
- *Invited Talk*, Econometrics Workshop, MIT (2005)
- *Presenter*, Political Methodology Summer Conference, Florida State University (2005)

Other

Languages: English (native); Spanish (conversational; translator, 1999 Pan American Games)
International: Professional work in 30+ countries across Africa, Asia, Europe, and Latin America; lived in Hanoi (2009–2011) and Budapest (2015–2017)